natural to appoint a former Indian Foreign Service officer as national security adviser, given that the job entails conducting diplomacy on behalf of the prime minister. The problem with that argument manifests in the fear that the national security adviser would end up encroaching on the powers of the foreign secretary and would end up like the erstwhile Secretary General, a kind of super foreign secretary.

In any case, the Ministry of External Affairs is not the only remit of the national security adviser. Internal security issues also take up a large part of their daily routine. This includes internal security and intelligence matters as well as defence and nuclear issues as the national security adviser is part of the nuclear command and control structure. Since 1999 there have been five NSAs, of whom three came from the foreign service while the other two – including the current one – were police service officers with intelligence backgrounds. Officials complain that just as former diplomats tend to meddle in the working of the Ministry of External Affairs while serving as national security adviser, former police or intelligence officers end up acting as super cop or super intelligence official.

Over the years the national security advisers have attempted to take powers, especially those related to intelligence, away from the Ministry of Home Affairs and a power struggle has periodically ensued between the national security adviser and the home minister. Like all bureaucratic fights, the outcome of that battle has varied depending on the strength of individual actors. One arena for contention relates to whomever gets to brief the prime minister on a daily basis. Former police officers designated as national security adviser have sought to wrest control of the daily briefing from the heads of the Intelligence Bureau (IB – the domestic intelligence service) and Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW – the external intelligence service). Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, tired of having to decide the dispute, discontinued the practice of being briefed